

BASIC BROADCAST JOURNALISM

CTE STANDARD CTB.03.01

FIELD REFERENCE

Most Common Framing Errors Handout

Essential visual composition guidelines for student journalists and camera operators

COMMON FRAMING ERRORS & SOLUTIONS

Headroom Mismanagement

ERROR 01

Incorrect vertical space between the subject's head and the upper frame boundary.

THE MISTAKE

Excessive headroom makes subject appear timid/sinking; insufficient headroom cuts off scalp awkwardly.

THE FIX

Align eyes along the upper horizontal third line with a slight cushion above the head.

Inadequate Lead & Nose Room

ERROR 02

Failing to leave open space in the direction the interview subject is facing.

THE MISTAKE

Framing the subject against the screen edge makes them look claustrophobic or like talking into a wall.

THE FIX

Place subject on the opposite side of the frame so they speak into the open two-thirds space.

Joint Chopping

ERROR 03

Cutting off human anatomy directly at natural body joints with the frame boundary.

THE MISTAKE

Framing across the neck, elbows, wrists, knees, or ankles creates an illusion of severed limbs.

THE FIX

Always frame slightly above or below joints (e.g., mid-chest for MCU, mid-thigh for MLS).

"Bullseyeing" (Over-Centering)

ERROR 04

Placing the subject's face dead-center in the middle of the broadcast frame.

THE MISTAKE

Wastes upper frame space and creates a static, dull composition for news interviews.

THE FIX

Apply Rule of Thirds: align subject on vertical grid lines with eyes on top intersection points.

Background Merges ("Tree Head")

ERROR 05

Background elements aligning directly with the subject's head or body.

THE MISTAKE

Poles, light fixtures, or trees appear to grow out of the subject's head, distracting viewers.

THE FIX

Uneven Horizons

ERROR 06

Accidentally tilting the camera, resulting in crooked horizontal background lines.

THE MISTAKE

Tilted background lines make professional news footage look amateurish and disorienting.

THE FIX

Shift camera/subject slightly and open aperture (lower f-stop) for shallow depth of field.

Check and center the tripod bubble level or turn on gridlines before pressing record.

QUICK REFERENCE MATRIX

FRAMING ERROR	VISUAL SYMPTOM	ROOT CAUSE	ON-SET CORRECTION
Excessive Headroom	Dead space above head; subject sinks	Camera tilted up too far	Tilt camera down; place eyes on top third line
Lacking Nose Room	Subject talks directly into frame edge	Subject on wrong side of third grid	Pan camera to open space in direction of look
Joint Chopping	Subject cropped at neck, knees, elbows	Improper focal length or zoom choice	Adjust zoom to crop mid-chest, torso, or thigh
Background Merge	Poles/plants sprouting from head	Deep depth of field & bad positioning	Step subject aside; open aperture to blur background
Unlevel Horizon	Slanted background room lines	Tripod head uneven	Center tripod bubble level before shooting

5-POINT PRE-RECORD FIELD CHECKLIST



1. Level

Tripod bubble centered?



2. Eyes

On top third gridline?



3. Nose Room

Open space in gaze direction?



4. Background

No objects sprouting from head?



5. Cut Points

Frame breaks between joints?